

Does the claim that God exists outside of time give us
reason to reject premise (2) of the foreknowledge
argument?

It does look like, if Aquinas' view is right, (2) is false. That
is good for the defender of free will.

We'll shortly consider some ways of responding to Edwards' argument. But first let's think about how Edwards' argument might be related to an argument for fatalism.

Suppose that someone did not believe in God — and hence rejected premise (2) of Edwards' argument — but did believe that there were truths about all of our future actions. Could they give an argument similar to Edwards' argument?

There are truths
about our future
actions.

We have no
choice about the
past.

In the past, God
had
foreknowledge of
our future
actions.

To get a grip on this, imagine that one learned of another universe, which had its own system of time and space. And suppose one was given all of the information about everything that ever happens in that universe, and the time at which it happens. So, in particular, you know everything about every free action in that universe. But it's not like you knew of every action **before** that action occurred — you don't exist in the time of that universe.

Let's look again at the premises which make
reference to time.

1. We have no choice about past facts.
2. In the past, God had foreknowledge of our future actions.
3. We have no choice about the fact that God knows that in the future I will perform a certain action. (1,2)

We started off with two arguments for the reality of fate.

The first was the Logical Argument for Fate, which was based on the Law of the Excluded Middle.

The law of the excluded middle

For any proposition P , either P is
true or $\text{Not-}P$ is true.

Could we say that neither of these are true (or false), but that
both simply lack truth-value?

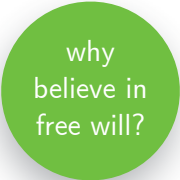
But what if we denied this? Recall the two propositions about the future we discussed earlier:



two
arguments
against free
will



is fate
real?



why
believe in
free will?



three
ways out

You will get married
on July 1, 2030.

You will not get married
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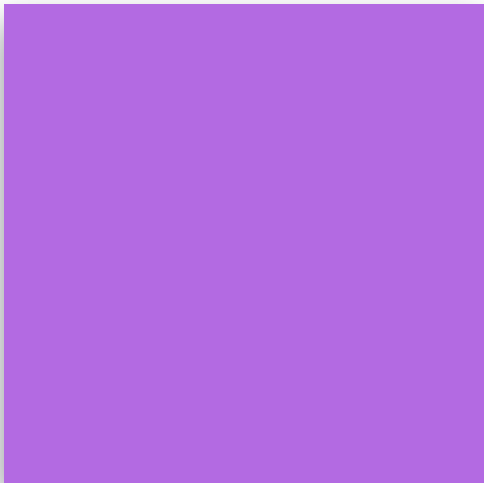
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3. We have not checked that

God knows that in the end I will

1. We have no choice about past facts.

performance: (1, 2)

2. In the past, God had foreknowledge of

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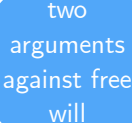
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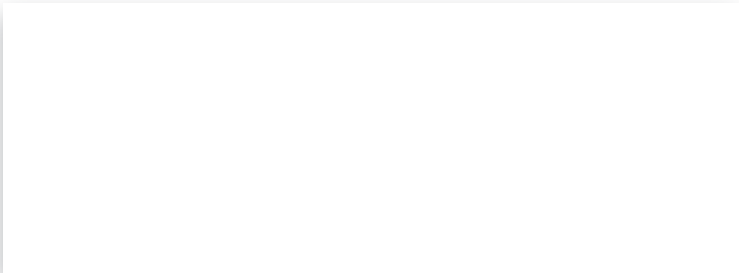
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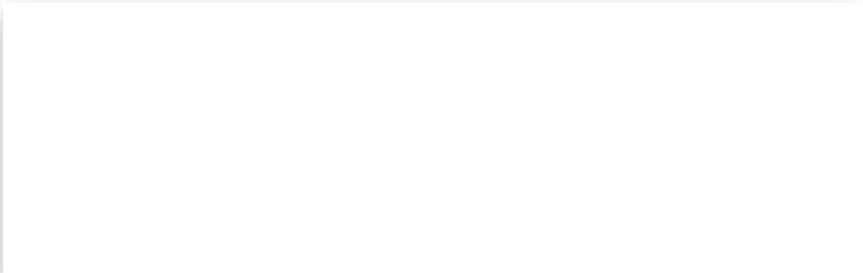
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(5) Let's look at what happens if we

with reference to the being of truth about

replace reference to God's foreknowledge

God only shows up in premises (2) and

our future actions.



perform a certain action (1,2)

1. We have no direct facts.

2*In the past, there were truths about

all of our activities.

3 We have not the fact that

then we have the choice about q.

4. If we have no choice about p , and no

acaioid.

some action, then I will prefer that

choice about the fact that if p , then q ,

God knows that in the future I will

5* We have noticed that the fact

will perform various actions.



0 We have achieved what we

that if it is true that I will perform

(3, 4, 5)

The fatalist argument

a Predictor. By the above line of thought, this person would lack free will. But

So now consider a possible scenario in which someone exactly like you would get

never had any. So they lacked free will before getting a Predicto.

that Predict did not **take away** their free will; it just shows them that they

either.

But this person was stipulated to be exactly like you. So you don't have free will,

and the example of the Predictor — which seem to show that if there is such a

things as fate, then there is no free will.

So far we've looked at two imaginary thought experiments—the story of Osmo,

Our question is: do either fatigue or foreknowledge pose a

serious challenge to the reality of free will?

Our first topic today is the oldest challenge to the existence of free will: the challenge to

freedom that comes from fate.

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The law of the excluded middle

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true or $\text{Not-}P$ is true.

'undetermined.' They do not now have any truth-value

But what if we denied this? Perhaps about future free

(though they will later).

actions—like claim about what you will eat for dinner

tonight — are neither true nor false, but simply

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